

Andrew Ross in his Brooklyn studio.
photo by Capri Wayne

From Visual Major to World-Traveling Brooklyn Studio Artist

Dreyfoos alum Andrew Ross is perpetually on the hunt, following the motto of his high school sculpture teacher.

ANDREW ROSS'S STUDIO IS located toward the north end of Jay Street in the Dumbo (Down Under the Manhattan Bridge Overpass) neighborhood. Flanked between the views of the Manhattan Bridge and the shining East River stands a Neoclassical building of 11 floors. The floor where Andrew's studio is located features a high-ceilinged hallway with exposed aluminum pipes and large monocolored paintings on the wall, giving the impression of an artistic space.

Named by art critic Jarrett Earnest as "one of the major sensibilities of his generation," the visual art alum (class of 2007) has established himself as a studio artist in Brooklyn.

In school, Ross dabbled in painting and printmaking. He shares fond memories of the late Mrs. Christo, his former printmaking teacher.

"I spent a lot of time with her," Ross said, recounting all the extra hours he spent in the school studios. "Everyone loved her. She was in the printmaking studio after school a lot and we'd hang out there. I made a lot of prints. But they were experimental… not traditional prints."

However, his favorite class was always sculpture. He cites one teacher in particular that he got to know very well – Mr. Griffin. "We made a lot of stuff there," Ross said. "He would let me stay late to do extra projects. I learned how to weld there, which is very rare in high school."

"Mr. Griffin used to always say that it's about the hunt," Ross said, dressed in a Commes de Garçons T-shirt and pin-striped pants. "He always said 'it's about the hunt', about anything. I bike a lot now, and I think that biking is really good for your mental health. Especially [going] from your home to your workplace because… there's the drive to get something done once you get there… it feels like 'you're on the hunt'."

"I think that was a way of saying that the journey is more important than the result and that your lifestyle is more important than even the work," Ross said, behind a pair of thin gold-rimmed glasses. "I remember Mr. Griffin lived on a boat. So, he had a very particular lifestyle."

Attending an art school prepared him for his college experience, according toRoss. He went to Cooper Union, a private university in New York, known renowned for its art, architecture, and engineering programs.

"[Cooper] was super, super competitive," Ross said. "You kind of see everyone who's making stuff that you're interested in. You see their work, even if you're not in their classes. You see it as you walk in, or as you walk around the studios."

As Ross described, being surrounded by other creatives was often daunting. He felt added pressure as a result of his "almost entirely critique based" classes.

"The classes are literally just everyone in the room showing their work one by one and talking about it, and it used to get kind of intense," Ross said. "People would cry—some other students were kind of scary to be in a critique with."

"There's one [art piece] that I made that had a lot of critiques and mixed reactions," Ross said. "I think 90 percent of the class



Chassis, Solo exhibition, Installation View (2017), by Andrew Ross
Courtesy of the Artist and Clima Gallery



The Mic is Mightier Than the Pen (2019) by Andrew Ross
EPS foam, Aqua resin, pigment, & wood
Photo Courtesy of the Artist

didn't like it, and ten percent did. Now that I look back on it, I think it was one of the best things I made in college, but they weren't ready." He laughed.

Ross has since become a self-sustaining studio artist by creating successful art pieces, garnering acclaim from critics and curators both in New York City and Milan, where he participated in Milan Design Week during the second week of June.

Ross's artworks are "encrypted" in a way. Looking at the works in his studio, it's not always easy to detect a discernible message. There's the pastel sculptures, the collage of 3D-printed everyday objects, and the brand new home-decor installation. Ross's works could invoke mental images of album covers, video games, and even online memes. Such mental correlations make sense after hearing Ross's explanation of his style.

"It's about deconstructing commonplace objects," Ross says. "It used to be more about taking the actual things apart. And now it's more about recreating and recombining figures and images that exist in popular culture."

Despite his success, Ross keeps on hunting. As an independent studio artist, he recognizes the importance of getting one's art displayed. The key is social networking, according to Ross.

"Ultimately, it's about being recommended," he said. "Going out to openings and making yourself known to other artists and art appreciators. In New York, studio visits are very important."

In responding to the sentiment of art not being a viable career path, Ross tells an anecdote.



fight loop (2021) by Andrew Ross
Thermoplastic, epoxy coating, polyurethane, paint, aluminum, stainless steel, plywood
Photo by Daniel Terna, Courtesy of the Artist

"One time, I did a residency in Switzerland, so I lived in Switzerland for six months," Ross said.

"On their $100 bill is a sculpture by Alberto Giacometti. When I first saw that, I thought it was hilarious because people think you can't make money with art, but there's a sculpture on the $100 bill in one of the richest countries in the world."

To explain how he makes his income, Ross breaks his streams of money into three outlets: teaching art, selling art, and creating art for film and television. For example, he's worked on art for HBO shows. As far as teaching goes, Ross is preparing to teach his first college level class this fall semester.

Most days, Ross will ride his bike for 45 minutes from his apartment to the studio and work there for as long as he can. On a sunny Sunday afternoon, his work on his latest painting, "Siddhartha Leaving the Palace on the Carried White Horse", might be interrupted by a visit from his family who live in South Florida.

Even when he accompanies his parents and little sister to check out Dumbo market, poses for family selfies by the East River, or visits Jane's Carousel at Brooklyn Bridge Park, he can be seen absorbed in his thoughts. He wasn't going to ride the carousel, but was eventually convinced by his stepfather and sister.

When asked afterward, Ross said, "I was meditating, and wondering what it is like to ride on a horse that is carried by people."